



ILLUSTRATION BY SIDDHANT JUMDE

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mal” phase, a “thrift-core” phase, a “quiet luxury” phase, a “streetwear drop” phase, and a “clean girl” phase, often without leaving their room. The point is not the fixedness of taste. The point is the freedom to try on versions of the self.

This is also the reason why brands

are no longer the last word on meaning. In particular, legacy brands face the challenge of not being specific or differentiated enough. They cater to too wide an audience to be useful for defining identities sharply. In the meaning-making world, they are blunt instruments that do not

offer the excitement of the new. The other truth is that Gen Z does not treat brands with reverence—they do not passively receive brand stories. They play with them, remixing them, making memes out of them. The delivered brand may not be what the brand intended; brands are often made or broken in the comments section.

In a world where the distance between desire and fulfilment has narrowed rapidly, thanks to quick commerce and instant payments, consumption becomes a function of mood rather than need. The meaning of impulse widens, and aligns with momentary needs that arise and must be fulfilled now. Consumption becomes like a little break from a routine, a way to dress up a moment with a little spice. Boredom, stress, pangs of insecurity become triggers for purchase—the category is not key, which emotion a brand caters to in the moment is.

Gen Z is interested in brands that have ‘purpose’ but this phenomenon is often both overstated and misunderstood. Mere proclamation of virtue does nothing. If a brand is genuinely invested in a cause or a larger goal and demonstrates this through its actions, then that registers. But it is by no means the single most important factor.

The behaviour of Gen Z is often seen to be a cipher, but this is really not the case. They cannot be understood in terms of older generation because their life context is so different. But put the two together and this generation begins to make sense. That doesn’t mean that their behaviour is predictable, just that it is explainable. This is a generation that has been tasked with creating new rules and then living by them, and consumption is a key part of their sense-making apparatus. **BT**

Views are personal